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Ray Sherman

Ray Sherman was born in Chicago in 1923 but has been an integral part of the west coast music scene for many years. His first exposure came in L.A. in 1939 and he gained valuable experience in the Army with Ray Bauduc and Gil Rodin. Ray was part of the thriving L.A. studio scene for 35 years and found time to tour with Benny Goodman and play clubs with Doc Cheatham and Jack Sheldon. He maintains a healthy interest in new developments in music, and his Arbors recording "Ray Sherman at the Keyboard" employs extensive MIDI technology which yields swinging musical results.

Ray was interviewed in San Diego, California on February 13, 1998, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: We are filming at the San Diego Jazz Party. My name is Monk Rowe and we're here for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive. And I am very pleased to welcome jazz pianist Ray Sherman. And I want to call you a plumbing thing — but like a fixture on the west coast, all right? You've been here for most of your life.

RS: Yeah, I'm really a Chicagoan. Shall I plug my next album? It's called "Piano Chicago Style." But I really, as I was going through that and putting it together I really started, I'm a Chicagoan really. I moved out here, I was 16 years old. But I think your formative years, where you grow up—

MR: Well Chicago was a pretty darn good place to have some formative years, wasn't it?

RS: Sure. I started thinking about that, I was really fortunate. I mean even, this was like in the late '30s, well I mean all through the '30s, but I mean starting to listen to the swing bands and whatever, from about '35 on, and just the local bands, on the local radio stations, everything was so great. Then eventually they had got the networks together. But I say just growing up when radio first started, and there was a lot of good bands in Chicago that you could listen to.

MR: So many people mention the importance of radio in those days, and the live broadcasts too.

RS: Yeah.

MR: Not just the records.

RS: Oh no, that's what I mean, yeah, all the remotes they called them.

MR: Was the sound good?

RS: It sounded good to me. I don't know. Like we were talking about, you know when I did live T.V. and the balance was just terrible. And in those days they used to go — of course the bands just stayed in one place and the singer was there, they always knew it was the same set up. But they worked it out. And I don't think they used more than two or three

mics maybe, one on the piano and one in the front of the band. It sounded great to me. I don't know.

MR: Well it was partly the musicians' job to balance themselves, too, is that correct?

RS: Well that's what I say, I mean the guys went there and they were in a ballroom or whatever, a cafe, they played so it would sound good in the room. And it was up to the radio station to do what they could with that. But they didn't seem to have any problem.

MR: Well plus you weren't comparing it to sound fidelity these days.

RS: Oh no. I mean as far as the balance, you know, like all the instruments balanced correctly. I think they needed to put a mic in the piano probably.

MR: Who were some of your favorites in those radio days to listen to?

RS: I was just thinking about that. Well it's funny, in those days — well I guess, well Bob Zurke probably was the first piano player, with the Bob Crosby band.

MR: Pause for your coffee.

RS: Okay. Help my throat a little.

[pause]

They say warm stuff is good for your throat.

MR: Yeah.

RS: So are we rolling?

MR: Yeah. We were talking about Bob Zurke actually.

RS: Yeah, listening, as you say, starting to listen to the radio and hear the bands that I like, and getting to the age where it was really, gee, I want to listen to that. Say '35, '6. I think the Bob Crosby band from the Black Hawk. I think — who did they — they followed Coon-Sanders I think was in there before, who didn't impress me too much. But the Bob Crosby band, and then hearing Bob Zurke. I was very impressed with him. And of course on records Teddy Wilson I guess was the next.

MR: Was the Bob Crosby band with Bob Haggart at that time?

RS: That's right.

MR: Ray Bauduc?

RS: That's right. That's where they wrote "The Big Noise" from Black Hawk.

MR: At the Black Hawk.

RS: That's right. They had matinees — well they told the story so often.

MR: Well you can tell it.

RS: They had matinees either Saturdays or Sundays where the college kids used to come down and – I've forgot the whole story — but they just started improvising something, just the two of them once. And that made history.

MR: That's great. I know he just recently, well in the last couple of years, re-recorded that tune, without the whistling. I think he had a guitar player.

RS: Yeah I think I heard that.

MR: That's cool.

RS: Well yes, it's a great tune you know, do it a lot of different ways.

MR: I understand your parents were musicians?

RS: Yes. That was one of the bands that I listened to on the air, was my dad's band.

MR: Oh, I didn't know that.

RS: Yeah. Morey Sherman. People from Chicago that remember that period, you know, this is '20s and '30s would remember him. And my mother also, she worked with a harp and she played violin and she worked with a harpist. They had a harp and violin duo and they played like light classics and things like that. And they were on the air too.

MR: Would they play dinner clubs and stuff like that?

RS: Yeah dinner, a lot of dinner music.

MR: So do you remember, as a kid, you thought your parents were pretty cool because they were out playing gigs?

RS: I guess I was impressed — I mean I took it for granted until kids used to come up and say oh is your father Morey Sherman? Yes. And I said gee I must be special, I didn't know it was, until that happened. I mean all the music around all the time, that was great. But as far as being special, I didn't realize it until the kids came up.

MR: That was what they did for a living I guess.

RS: Yeah. And he was very well known around Chicago, my dad. When radio came in he was like on the air three times a day from different places. He'd work like a tea dance and then he'd work a dinner shift, and then he'd go someplace else later at night, all different places. And of course the stations, I guess that was great, they filled up a lot of time with remote broadcasts from the different places. And so he was like a big name in Chicago.

MR: Did they ever talk much about the Depression years?

RS: Yeah, as a matter of fact. So we're talking about — well it didn't really hit them until about I think it must have been '33, '34, '32. The crash was 1929. They had their money in real estate, and it took about — and he made good money, he had a Cadillac and he had a raccoon coat and all that. But they invested it in real estate, and the whole thing I guess, by 1933, everything was, you know mortgages foreclosed and all that kind of stuff. Yeah, I knew about that. But of course he kept working and he earned a living. But after that it wasn't smooth sailing.

MR: It changed your family lifestyle?

RS: Not very much because they hung on to a couple of buildings. They were in partners with my uncle. And so there was apartments that was available to them. So that helped, that their rent was taken care of. But yeah, I remember, you know, no more Cadillacs. It was a '28 Cadillac I think, I remember it.

MR: What got you — you took piano lessons from your aunt?

RS: That's where I started, my mother's sister. And that made it easy. And then eventually I guess when I got into my teens they had me go with like a more accomplished teacher who also worked as a professional musician. He played either "The Romance of Helen Trent" or something — the one that had "Clair de Lune" as a theme song. He's the one that played that. So he worked in radio, but he was an accomplished concert pianist. They sent me to him and he made me do a recital, just like, you're going to be a concert pianist. Which, it's good experience.

MR: Yeah, if you can handle that—

RS: Yeah. It helps. It's kind of like what we're going to do here, get used to — but playing note for note, to me that's still hard. Gosh, I mean you have to hit exactly what's on the music.

MR: Right. The definition of a mistake becomes much clearer at that point.

RS: That's right.

MR: So, gee moving from Chicago to the west coast, it was like a big thing. Did you want to?

RS: Oh yeah. It was economics. I mean like you're talking about the Depression and all that, and in those days, well I guess any days, I'm talking about my dad, when you get older, they want new faces and stuff, and he'd been around Chicago for so long. He didn't want to travel because he was a real family man, like it got to, in the late 30s, the bands just went on the road, that's the only way, you couldn't stay in one place. And he didn't want to do that because he had kids. And the jobs kept getting, the status kind of went down over the years, and he thought well maybe he could start out here. But I think he really had myself, and I have an older brother who sang, he had us in mind, if we're going to start our career that would sure be a good place to start, in Los Angeles. So that was another one of the reasons.

MR: What was the reputation of Los Angeles at that time?

RS: Well '39, oh sure, this was just like the reputation now, I mean as far as being a center for the entertainment, I mean the studios were — out here, I mean I'm talking about Los Angeles.

MR: It wasn't so much the live music?

RS: Oh no. The studio work, yeah. I guess by that time we all knew that's the most secure place to be, I guess he thought — he wasn't hoping for me to be on the road the rest of my life either, which I mean I would have loved to go and play in a swing band. But it's funny they never — they didn't say don't, but I think they had in mind that it would be better if I could get into the studios, that would be much better.

MR: Instead of crisscrossing the country on a train or in a bus.

RS: You know, even, I guess especially like with Goodman and Miller and all those guys. What were they, four weeks maybe in one place? Not for any length of time.

MR: Some of the, like the Basie band or whatever, they'd be more one-nighters even so it had to be tough.

RS: Yeah, well even in my dad's day it's like you'd play a location for four to six weeks. And of course back east you would do one-nighters in the summertime. Like during the winter you'd be four or six weeks here, and then jump around. And during the summer months you'd go on one-nighters.

MR: So was it before you left or after that you first started playing out in ensembles?

RS: Well I moved to Los Angeles, I was 16, so I joined the union there. And I was still going to school, I would work weekends, club dates they would call them. It wasn't — I mean not a lot of guys want to take a chance on a 16-year-old, but my dad knew, people knew him and so he contacted people, and I got to working. Piano players you know can do so many things. I played in a couple of places where it was piano alone with vocalists, and as soon as I graduated high school, which I was 17 when I graduated, then I got to working steady like doing that. It was kind of like cocktail place that had singers, and you'd play for them. And oh I don't know if anybody remembers Jimmy Walsh, that was the first band that I got to play with. And that was at the Casino Gardens, that's kind of famous, in Ocean Park. So that was my first band. He had a good band, he played trombone very good. Like about a 12-piece. You know it's a ballroom, Casino Gardens. Well see one thing — I didn't play with any name people. I arranged for Jan Savitt, before I went in the service. I was 19 when I went in the service. So I arranged for Jan Savitt and just when I got my draft notice, he sent me a telegram to come and join the band right at that time.

MR: And you joined the service, was it around '44 or '43?

RS: '43.

MR: Was it at that time, when you were going in the service, was it a question of I'm going overseas?

RS: Well it's funny I don't know, in those days people, I don't know, they weren't as sensitive about it, maybe it's since the Vietnam thing. Like if you could work deals, you know, nobody put you down. If you had connections where you could stay in the country for the duration or whatever, I mean it was fine, go do it. And my dad knew Gil Rodin, you are familiar with him? And he was up in Vallejo with Ray Bauduc, they were both in the same group up there. And I don't know how my dad knew that, but he contacted Gil and told him I was going to be drafted, and if he could work something out that I could go up and join their band. And of course the Army bands were always looking for guys. And I think it was a legitimate thing, I mean you just couldn't pull somebody that just

happened to come to the base, you know, oh, there's a piano player. I mean you had to get them from someplace. So Gil said he'd see what he could do to get me up there. Because they did need a piano player.

MR: Well quite a few of the people I've talked to had positive musical experiences in the military.

RS: Yeah. Well they were considered important you know, morale and all that stuff. We played parades, we played the dances and the officers clubs, we were working almost every day. So yeah I think they thought it was important.

MR: In the draft, in those days, it was just expected, right, almost? You were going to go in the service.

RS: Yeah, any physically able guy, I mean in a certain age limit, sure. And well I didn't tell the whole story, but anyhow I was drafted and they sent me to Texas for Basic Training, which was out of the — whatever they call it — Vallejo is in a certain region there, whatever they call it. And Texas is a different region. And I got there and the guys are telling me you know, oh they'll never get you because this is in a different region, they can't do that. And I had almost given up and we were getting to the end of Basic Training. And you know you wonder how things happen — I got the flu and they put me in the hospital, so I was there a little longer than the other guys in my training unit. And I was in the hospital and one of the — what did they used to call them, the guys in the office — came up and said hey your thing came through to go to California. It's funny I wasn't scared or whatever, but when I think back on it, that was like, by a thread.

MR: A timely illness at that point.

RS: Well I've often wondered, like if I would have been shipped out. Well no, I had something up my sleeve. They had a good band there. It was Camp Wallace in Texas, near Houston. And the band leader there told me well gee if they don't send for you we could use you.

MR: They can always use a good piano player.

RS: I guess at Texas — a little better I suppose. No Texas is great now. In those days it wasn't considered too terrific.

MR: Right. When you returned to California after the service, is this when the studios beckoned you?

RS: Yeah. I keep saying, oh it took a while, but I never thought about it. We got back and well I had worked with Bauduc in the service, and — see I should write all this down for my memoirs. At one point, no that's right, I came back, oh, I went to work with Savitt. That was first guy, back at the Casino Gardens. And he had the band in there and I worked with him and wrote a couple of arrangements, and for a few weeks, they used to change bands every three or four weeks. And it was coming to the end of that

engagement and he called me in the back and he says — oh and then after that, Will Osborne had contacted me, that he was going to go up and down the coast with forming new band, and would I come with him. He got Jimmy Mundy is writing the book, and Eileen Wilson is going to be the singer. And I said I never had been on the road with a band. That's what I'd always — gosh wouldn't that be great you know. So anyhow before we were through on the Savitt thing, he called me back and he said, "Ray, what are you going to be doing after this?" I said, "oh Will Osborne called me and I'm probably going to do that, go up and—" He said, "gee I think you ought to stick around town, I may have a radio show." And I thought oh I don't want to do that, I want to be with a swing band on the road. And he did. He got the — what was the movie, not Hedda Hopper the other one —

MR: I probably won't know this.

RS: Yeah, well it'll come to me. But anyhow he got this show. He was a fiddle player. He loved classical music. And it was like a string quartet and there probably was celeste or something, I think there was a keyboard on it. And the theme song was "Pictures at an Exhibition."

MR: No kidding.

RS: Yeah. Because it was about movies.

MR: Aha, there you go.

RS: So that was his thing. I'll think of her name, gosh this kind of fat lady. But anyhow, I didn't want to do that, I mean gosh, I didn't want to settle down. And the road trip was terrible because the drummer was just terrible. Everybody was great except him. You know if you have a bad drummer, forget it, you know no matter how good everybody else is, and good arrangements. So I learned my lesson.

MR: So much for the road.

RS: Yeah. That was the last time.

MR: No kidding?

RS: Yeah. I went up to San Francisco a couple of times with Savitt. It must have been after that. But I'm on the road now.

MR: So did you end up doing the radio thing?

RS: Oh, so then I worked a little around town with Savitt, and worked with Jerry Wald I remember, Trocadero's, you know places around town. I'm trying to think when I got the Judy Canova's show. No the first one was Abe Burrows. Do you remember him?

MR: No.

RS: Oh he's famous as a musical comedy script writer. But he wasn't then, but he was like a writer for whatever. And well you have to know who he was. He was a funny guy. He used to write these funny songs, and he would entertain at parties, and he got so famous

doing that that they hired him to do a radio show with these funny songs he used to write. But it was a good little band, Milton DeLugg — does that name ring a bell?

MR: Sure.

RS: It was his band, just a little group about five, six. And he wrote these real complex arrangements. We only — maybe one number we had, but it was really hard, and you had to really read it and we'd go in and rehearse and then we'd have like about two or three hours off before the show. I remember I'd come back to the show it was like I'd never seen this music before.

MR: And it was live of course, right?

RS: Yeah. There were two broadcasts I think, I'm pretty sure, or I think they had tape by those days. You know they had an east coast broadcast and a west coast broadcast. We didn't talk about the Tommy Dorsey—

MR: No, I was just looking at my notes here.

RS: Well that was when I was still in Chicago.

MR: We can rewind. Let's talk about that, and then I had something to ask you about in the service too.

RS: Well that just reminded me, about the east coast and the west coast. It was Tommy Dorsey, he had the Raleigh and Kool Show that was called "The Amateur Swing Contest." And it was a half hour show, and he would do it from whatever theater, you know they're touring around playing theaters, whatever town they were in, they would do the show, and they would have auditions, you know a couple of weeks before the band was coming in each town that they were in. And so I auditioned for that and I got on the show. And the first, the east coast broadcast I think it was Barnes, is that the guitar player?

MR: George Barns?

RS: George Barns I think won it. He was older than me. I was 15 and I think he was about 18 or 19. But you were supposed to be amateur, you couldn't belong to the union you know. And so he was eliminated and I won the west coast broadcast. Because in those days we should explain, there was no tape.

MR: In the show—

RS: In order to have it on at the same time in New York and at the same time in L.A., they had to do two broadcasts.

MR: Right. And who were the judges of this?

RS: The audience. The applause meter.

MR: Oh, yeah, okay. Like Ted Mack.

RS: Yeah, in a big theater, you know that makes sense.

MR: Cool.

RS: Yeah. So on the second broadcast I got the most applause.

MR: And you played "Honeysuckle Rose?"

RS: I played "Honeysuckle Rose," and I remember — are you familiar with the Dorsey Brothers record of "Honeysuckle Rose?"

MR: A little bit.

RS: Because I had memorized all the solos out of that, and I played a little bit of Tommy Dorsey's solo, and I kept looking at him and he just didn't react at all. Maybe he thought I was putting him on.

MR: Maybe he didn't recognize it.

RS: Well he played [scats], which is another tune that he incorporated, so I thought it would be pretty obvious.

MR: Well that's neat. What did you get for that prize?

RS: Oh, I won some money, I forgot how much. But the biggest thing is as a special thing my dad took me to the Black Hawk after the broadcast.

MR: To the what?

RS: To the Black Hawk to see the Bob Crosby band, which I'd never seen live. And he knew, God I loved this band, I listened every night on the radio.

MR: He was probably pretty proud of you at that time. Neat.

RS: Oh yeah. And he introduced me, of course they all knew him. And so I got to meet everybody.

MR: Cool.

RS: Yeah. I guess I remember that more than anything.

MR: I wanted to ask you about, in the service, was the service bands that you were in, was it totally segregated at that time?

RS: Oh yeah. Definitely. Yeah, which is not nice but I don't think anybody even talked about it in those days.

MR: It wasn't an issue at that time.

RS: No. It's funny, I don't remember it ever coming up. We had Latin guys in that, except when we went to Texas it was a problem for the Latin guys. Remember we were really reminiscing. We eventually left Vallejo and we were transferred to a couple of different places and we ended up at Fort Hood. It was Camp Hood then, in Texas. And we went on one-nighters with a bond selling show. We'd go to all these different towns and they would have these Purple Heart guys come in and they would demonstrate how you jump — like battle scenes they would demonstrate.

MR: No kidding.

RS: Yeah, like in big outdoor places.

MR: Mock invasions and all that.

RS: Yeah. And they would do that. And I think we probably played some marches, and then after they would have like a dance, with the USO or something and we would play for that. And then we were touring around, and then some of the guys would go into bars. I didn't drink but they told me this, that you know we had a couple of Latin guys in the band, and they'd go into bars and they had like a white line back before you got up to the bar. And the Latin guys had to stand behind that, well they couldn't come up to the bar, they had to stand behind that white line. I guess somebody bought the drinks and brought it to them. You know, terrible.

MR: Oh dear.

RS: And I mean I guess that's only one of the things I didn't realize that Latin, Mexican Americans, had that — then I found out, I'd never heard that. But that's as far as race things, that's the only thing I was aware of during the service.

MR: When you got into the studio scene, it was in Los Angeles, is that right?

RS: Um hum.

MR: Did you have any idea that you'd be making a thirty-some year career out of that?

RS: No. Let me think. We got back after, eventually well I got that, well I guess "The Judy Canova Show." Well see I was married by then and that made a difference. You know I didn't want to be traveling around either, we had a child and so that started to sound good to me, and especially gosh, all these great guys from the swing bands were in the studios and the radio orchestras and movie studios. And I was talking about Burrows and that band, Vince Terry was the guitar player, I don't know if you know any of these names, but they were all first class players, and of course Milton. God I had seen Milton playing with Manny Klein and Matty Malneck, you know that little group that they had, I think they had, Matty Malneck had a little group, he was a fiddle player. I think that was where Milton got his start, and Manny Klein was the trumpet player. Gosh you'd play with guys like that, it's not like when I was in Chicago and the studio bands were really corny, especially the Chicago bands, you know the house bands. I listened to the remotes. There were standing programs with the house bands and they were really pretty corny. They were old fashioned. But by after the war, they had the best swing players. So it sounded good to me and I remember a friend of mine, Bob Bain, a guitar player, he was I guess doing that show with — "The Judy Canova Show" — and he lived like in Beverly Hills, we lived way out in the end of the San Fernando Valley. And one night he came out, in person, to tell me that they're going to use me on "The Judy Canova Show." So it was status too, for musicians. Gosh, all these experiences are coming back to me. I did, after I'd been doing radio in the studios for a while I did — Stan Kenton did a show from the Palladium and he was always the piano player in his band, but this time he wanted to stand up, like the bands did, he was good at that anyhow, he looked great in front of the

band, so he was going to conduct, and he was going to hire a piano player for that, to play the band numbers. And they called me to do that. And I think Shelly Manne was in the band, and I forgot the trombone player. But I looked up to these guys, like that's the top of the world, you know, Stan Kenton's band. And that's when he was very big. And of course you know Shelly Manne was like winning *Down Beat* polls and all. And they were coming up to me and like thinking how great it was that I was in the studios see? And of course which eventually they got into. That was their goal, to do that.

MR: Yeah. It's interesting how sometimes you look at what other people are doing—

RS: The grass is greener.

MR: That's right. And they're looking at you and saying gee I want to do that.

RS: Yeah. Well of course they had had that. I mean I never had that so I would have probably got to that point too if I'd had it. But they had been there and done that, big jazz band guys, big band guys, and that was the next step, to get into the studio and do pictures and all that.

MR: So, being a studio musician, you go to work in the studio—

RS: Well it was all freelance when I — just when I got into it, they had contracts. Up until then, where they had house bands, all studios had their own group. And during that period I was doing radio. I did "The Phil Harris Show," and I'm trying to think of what shows I did, and I started to do records, and there was also quotas, if you did movie studio work, you could only do a certain number of records, you couldn't do radio at all I don't think. They tried to divide up the work among all. So I was like in that field, doing radio. And records. And then the contracts went out and it got to be everything was freelance. And that's when I started to get calls, to do picture calls. But I've always loved the idea that I never had a — because that was like going to an office, with those guys that were under contract to studios.

MR: Did this give you any — this is like a 90s question — did you get health benefits and all that kind of stuff for that kind of work?

RS: Not right away. It was, in fact it took a long time before they got that. But the scale was good. I mean compared to whatever other work there was, that was the best scale. And as I say with the contracts, you work on a yearly basis, whatever it was. You'd divide it up. That was guaranteed so much money a week. You signed up for a year. But anyhow when I got into it it was just — I don't know exactly but I know compared to other work it was the highest per hour scale, I guess a three hour minimum calls.

MR: Can you tell me what it was? Do you remember?

RS: I don't remember. I remember the radio shows were like $35, $36.

MR: For a three hour session?

RS: Well including the rehearsal and doing the show when I first started radio, I'm pretty sure that's what it was.

MR: Well that was decent money back then.

RS: Well as I say this was 19 — early 50s, maybe late 40s with the '49 or '50 or something. Anyhow so at that period I was doing a few radio shows and then I started to work — Ben Pollack called me. And I always thought, gee, that would be the ideal. You'd have a couple of radio shows, and then you work with a good jazz band in some club at night. And so that finally happened. And after a while I wasn't too crazy about going to the same place every night and playing the same tunes. You know, even with good guys. So you live and learn. But it was a good career move though. I mean I started out to be a jazz piano player, so I couldn't not do that if somebody asked me to do it. And I was with Pollack a long time. And I had probably two radio shows. I don't think I was getting record dates at that time. Because that would have conflicted. Because record dates are in the evening a lot. Nowadays they send a sub and all that. I don't think Pollack would have been too crazy about that. Although I probably could have done it. It never came up.

MR: This was what, a five or six piece group?

RS: Yeah. Like a Dixieland band, three horns and three rhythm. And Matty Matlock was in the band. He had record dates and stuff. And he used to send, like if they had a good sub that stood by — I probably could have done it. But anyhow it didn't come up. The job finished. It seems like everything kind of coordinated just right. It finished and then I started to get record date calls. Funny, that was the days of, I guess I don't know if they even called it rock & roll or rhythm & blues, with the triplets in the right hand [scats]. I started getting a lot of calls like that, where that's what they wanted.

MR: Can you recall some of the records you played on?

RS: Well I think the only hit I was on was something Lane — "Primrose Lane." And I think I faked an introduction on that, and they always say evidently whatever I did was good.

MR: It became a little hook.

RS: Yeah. Because I did a record date after that, it was funny, a friend of mine, Jack Marshall, the guitar player, it was one of his dates. And he came over to me and he said, "do you think you could play something like the guy played on the 'Primrose Lane' intro?"

MR: Well maybe.

RS: But I didn't realize that that was considered an important part of the record.

MR: Neat.

RS: But I think there was another one: "The Big Hurt" does that ring a bell?

MR: It sounds like something from one of the vocal groups.

RS: It was a solo singer, a female singer, the other was a male singer. And you know you could look them up and they're probably on some list. And that had a gimmick, Radio

Recorders got to be a famous place I guess, a recording studio. This was when they were kind of making the records. And the guy owned it you know, and he was the engineer, and he had this thing, he had some kind of filter that he'd put — it got a very strange sound if you ever hear it, there was an effect on it that he used.

MR: On the whole record or just the piano?

RS: There's a name for it. Yeah, I think it went through the whole record, a very ethereal kind of effect.

MR: A flanger or—

RS: Yeah one of those kind of things, that's right, exactly. There's a name for it, I've forgot what they call it. Like a filter that changes pitches and goes up and down the spectrum, kind of like that. Oh the gal sang good, she had good musicians, pretty good tune, for a pop tune. So I did a lot of them. As I say most of them weren't hits. But I got through it. They probably sold. For Capitol I think mostly I worked. And then I started getting movie calls. I remember working with Nelson Riddle on "L'il Abner" which may have been one of the — that's one story that I remember, it was one of the early calls I got. And it seemed like I kind of got in the pool, you know like the contractors have lists of people, and you get on their list and you start getting like two, three calls a week or something.

MR: Let's talk about live T.V. for a moment.

RS: Oh yeah, well I was thinking about the Hollywood Palace. It was actually taped, but I mean whatever they call it, live on tape. Well the Palace in Hollywood, it was an old theater they kind of made over. And I didn't realize it in those days, I guess I didn't expect that much, because I'd go home and listen to the show, and oh yeah I can hear myself or whatever. There was a film clip, part of the Nicholas Brothers, a biography of the Nicholas Brothers that they show every once in a while on A&E, and there's one of the things they did at the Hollywood Palace. And God it sounds like we're playing in a big gymnasium and the mic is at the other end. It's like they didn't even have our mics on. Like the mics were on the stage and we were like back, way off, almost up like where the balcony is, over to the side. That's where we were with glass all around us. But that's supposed to be for isolation so when the singer sings on the stage that the band isn't leaking into the mics. But it was. And it had been leaking into the mic so bad that they turned off our mics. Because that's what it sounded like. And I couldn't believe how — and now you see, like shows that are, they're live on tape, whatever, like the award shows and all that, and they get great balance.

MR: Well things have come a long way. Technology and all that has come a long way.

RS: And the music was always — how is it video-wise? Audio-wise was, nobody thought that was very important. And like we'd be a mile away from the singer and all of that. You

know it's terrible to try to do something decent. But that's why we're there. I finally figured out like they want the best guys there because even under the worst conditions it'll sound good if you have the best guys.

MR: Do you recall any times when things really fell apart?

RS: No. That's interesting. Of course it got to be, with tape, at first it was you were live to the east coast. I guess they still do like "The Tonight Show" and all that, it's live to the east coast, and they make a tape as they're doing a live show and they play that for the west coast. But it got to be that if there was a goof, it wasn't live ever, it was just taped. Oh Jerry Lewis, do you remember, he tried to do a live, boy he really wanted to do it live, and that was just before the Hollywood Palace went on. It was the Jerry Lewis Theater originally. And he's the one that had it all refurbished and put the sign out there and everything. And I don't know it lasted about eight weeks and it was a big flop. But yeah, he really wanted to do it live. And I don't remember any big goofs. Well you know they did all those Playhouse 90s and all those things.

MR: Right.

RS: People go on the stage every day and do stuff live. But the radio shows though, God those trumpet players in there, boop, you know a high B flat or C, at the very beginning of the show, there's the red light and boom, you know, and you never hear any big flubs. You think God, how can they do that? But I'm telling everything. Are you going to edit?

MR: Well some of it.

RS: But my first show on "The Phil Harris Show," I mean this was live, well I guess I should interpolate, there was tape, and Alice used to tape her numbers, Alice Faye, because she didn't want to deal with that. We taped it. I guess she performed it though, during the show, but they had a tape of it that they could splice in there, if she didn't like what she did, being broadcast. Now the first show I come on and the very first thing on the air, no announcements, "The Phil Harris Show," Phil had made a record where Stanley Reitsman played an intro on a record. Well Stanley was kind of famous, I don't know. And he wanted to do that number, and he wanted that intro, just like Stanley played it, and it's piano alone, no bass, no drums. And I had to play it note for note, which that's a hazard right there. And I'm just like those trumpet players must feel, waiting for that red light to go on, and the blood is draining, but I made it.

MR: Did you?

RS: So that was a good initiation for live radio.

MR: Tell me about the movie "Pete Kelly's Blues." You were involved with that?

RS: Yeah.

MR: Is that the one with Jack Webb?

RS: That's right. It's getting to be kind of a cult thing now. Because it wasn't really panned but there wasn't much good said about it when it first came out, but I notice now they play it on A&E, and on Movie Classics, and they say three stars. So I think people think more of it now than they did in those days. I always thought oh gee — have you seen it?

MR: Yeah. I've seen it.

RS: He's kind of trying to do Orson Welles or something, and he directed it. But I mean that's a pretty good model, Orson Welles. But I thought maybe the critics thought it was too derivative you know, the things, the way he directed the thing. But it was certainly original, with all the music.

MR: Well it's interesting too I think now that we look at that we see him doing the "Dragnet" thing, and that colors the way we look at him.

RS: Oh, personally, yeah.

MR: Because he was very similar, that kind of unique thing.

RS: Yeah. He didn't do much different in any of his roles. He's a little more animated I guess.

MR: But who was the singer in it? Peggy Lee?

RS: Well Peggy Lee was in it, and also Ella Fitzgerald.

MR: And, oh yes, but there's a scene in that movie where Peggy Lee is like in an institution.

RS: That's right.

MR: And she's singing this song, "I Can See a Rainbow/Red and yellow and —"

RS: Yeah. Arthur Hamilton wrote that.

MR: Oh it's a really touching scene.

RS: Yeah. No I say, I think people are seeing now. Maybe, like his intentions were really good, Jack, and what he was trying to do, even if everything didn't come off grade A, but you know he got close in a lot of those parts. So yeah, and the fact that it had respect for jazz, I mean guys that play jazz, and he gave us all credits. And so yeah, I did the soundtrack and I was also in the picture. Not all of the guys were, but some, a few of us were also in the picture. Some guys were too busy. See when you're photographed you don't get paid as much as when you record. That's called sideline. So a lot of them they couldn't really afford to take — it was 14 weeks or something that we had to commit to be on call and you have to be there. And the guys like Nick Fatool, he was on the soundtrack but he couldn't — he was too busy.

MR: Oh. He had somebody fake his part.

RS: Yeah. I think it was an acting part anyhow so maybe that issue didn't come up. But some of the guys were just too busy recording to be able to do that, and they knew that in front, that they wouldn't. But I guess with Nick, oh that'll work out because we need an actor for that anyhow.

MR: Did you think it was pretty cool to see yourself in that film?

RS: Yeah, it was kind of a kick, especially now, to see how young I was.

MR: Wow. Well then after your studio days you came back to —

RS: Well yeah, so 30 years passed, but that's when I was just freelancing in T.V. and movies and records you know for that. I don't think I worked any clubs after the thing with Pollack.

MR: But eventually you got to do the Bob Crosby, that special?

RS: Well yeah, I had worked a little around, he booked jobs around town. Yeah I still did single engagements, you know, like people would call me and I would do it. In fact I did like regular club dates — what do they call it — jobbing they call it in Chicago, you know private parties and stuff, it was all during that period. Because at least you could sit down and fake something even. A lot of it was society, like Lester Lanin or whatever, but it was rhythmic, and we worked with a guy who, once in a while we'd get to play a jazz solo, we had Ralph Collier — do you remember that name? He played drums I remember. He was with the Goodman band when Peggy Lee was in the band. And so we had good guys, Mike Croup was with the Raymond Scott band, I think he was the bass player, and the leader. It was a society band but the people had grown up during the swing era so we kind of played with a good feeling. So I mean Saturdays and Sundays and Fridays sometimes, you didn't usually get studio work on Saturdays and Sundays, so I could work that in.

MR: Because that would be overtime on the weekends?

RS: Yeah that's right, they would have to pay more, so you didn't get many calls for Saturday or Sunday.

MR: Were the studios integrated at all at that point?

RS: They began to be. When I first started to do it I don't remember. But then I remember Bill Green, do you know him?

MR: Bill Green?

RS: Yeah. Saxophone player, he just died recently, and Buddy Collette, and a few guys started coming in and they were right. They forced the issue because they were guys that could cut the stuff. So I haven't been doing, what, ten years or so now, I haven't done any. So I'm sure it's — I'm not sure, but I would hope that it's a lot more equal now.

MR: Now do you still get — I don't know if "residuals" is the correct word?

RS: Yeah that was good, that I think that came in about 1968, well we started getting residuals for I guess the best thing was live T.V., which would be like the Hollywood Palace. If they show clips from that now we would get money. And I've noticed that a lot of — they're doing Johnny Carson or what's the gal the comedian that had a show — and they're doing just I think it's on The Family Channel. And it says you know, like re-runs of the Carson Show or something. And it's just the comedy stuff. And I think they re-did

the theme, I think Tommy Newsom did that, so they spent money on that, but I mean like I was on with Pete Fountain, well he always had a singer, I mean he had music on his show, but evidently they just do the comedy skits on that, and that's why, because they have to pay royalties, residuals. Now T.V. film, there's still no residuals. Like all that stuff they play at Nick at Nite, which I did a lot of that, all those situation comedies from that period.

MR: Too bad.

RS: Yeah.

MR: Gee, because that's going to be around for —

RS: Well they probably wouldn't be playing it as much if they had to pay residuals on it. If they turn it into a video they have to pay something. But if they just play it on television, they can play it a million times. Like we have a, like a fund where when movies were shown on television we get money. And they put all this stuff in a fund and they send you checks, once a year, you know all the movies you were in, or if they take T.V. shows and they make them into a video or they make them into a special, which they've done, like they take pieces of different T.V. shows and they make a whole new retrospective or something, then you get something. But anyhow they put that all in the fund.

MR: It's kind of like surprise money when you get it.

RS: Yeah. No, it's been nice, yeah. And the gal in the office there said it would probably be more of that as the year 2000 comes, that they'll be putting together these retrospective things, to show on T.V. I'd sure like to see more of the Palace. I haven't seen too many of those.

MR: Well you've had some nice recordings on Arbors Records. You play with some of their folks. And I wanted to just put this —
[audio interlude]

RS: That's not Mel Powell, is it?

MR: Now we could play a little guessing game with someone — say how many people are here, right? So when you decided to put this one man recording together, it's an interesting concept because the tunes are quite seasoned. Older tunes.

RS: Oh you mean to do older tunes with the new technology. Yeah I guess I figured why not? I mean it's there. I always liked the idea of being like a one man band, as an arranger I like that idea, and also playing as a soloist, I like the idea of having a little bass so it isn't so naked, to have a little bass and guitar or something in there and make it full. So that was the main reason. It isn't though, as comfortable as playing with three live guys.

MR: Did you have a click track when you did this?

RS: Maybe a couple of numbers I did. But I tried to just do — I would sit down and play the piano part first, and then what they call I would sweeten it, that's the term they use, and

I'd put in the other stuff. And I think a couple of numbers towards, after I got into it, because I noticed maybe, I don't know if all soloists, like if you put it on a metronome, there are variations in tempo when a guy's playing alone. So I don't know, a couple of numbers, well let me try it with a click, like you say, or some kind of sound, and play along with it. And a couple of numbers felt pretty comfortable that way so I did it.

MR: Did you do this in the studio or were you at home?

RS: I did it in my master bedroom, which I made into a MIDI workstation. Oh yeah, it's fun, I mean it's a real challenge, very time consuming, but no I like that idea of working with everything, having complete control of every element. When you go into it you don't realize how much time it's going to take, because you're doing the job of eight guys or something, it's bound to take longer.

MR: Plus a lot of music goes on a CD these days.

RS: Well that's it you have to do a lot. Well I got away with 50 something.

MR: Yeah, but that's still a lot.

RS: Yeah. And I really don't understand that. I think it's too much. When you go out — the normal set when you go out and play a job is 45 minutes.

MR: Right.

RS: So I don't know why it should be longer, I mean just from the listener's standpoint. Well I think people just like play it in the background going on, so they want it long. Or because the CD will take that much time they think they have to put it on there.

MR: When you get to festivals and parties like this, there's a certain standard number of tunes that you expect people to call. Do you ever get in a situation where people call things you don't know?

RS: Oh well first of all it's whoever's the leader on the set, you know, will call the tunes. And oh yeah, once in a while there'll be something that, very seldom that I never heard of or heard, but I might say oh gee I'm not that familiar with that or that comfortable, or I haven't played it that often. Or a lot of times if we get together before the set, like, "do you know this tune?" Oh well, "how's it go?" And okay, now where's the bridge, goes into what, D flat, or whatever, just to refresh your memory, so then it's no problem. It's like if you've heard the tune, if the tune itself is familiar to you, it's really not that big a problem if you have a little time ahead to think it over and what key and oh that kind of modulates here and that, okay. So there's not very many tunes from that period that I'm not familiar with as far as that I've heard.

MR: What do you listen to these days yourself?

RS: You know I got a nice set, I subscribe to Gerard Schwarz, do you know that name? He's conductor of the Seattle Symphony. He was originally a trumpet player, like a virtuoso, and he became a conductor, it must have been like 20 years ago. I remember seeing him

at the Pasadena, the small chamber orchestra. And now in Seattle he puts out this thing of a two CD package of like the basic repertoire of symphony orchestras, and each set is a different composer. So one CD is the music, and the other CD is like a lecture, with excerpts from the music and explaining the form and a little bit of the history of the guy's life and the period, and it's very good. And like you're just listening to — I'd had most of the stuff on LP, you know the music, but people say they don't like CDs, I don't understand any of it. To me it's so clear, no background noise.

MR: Yeah. Some people miss, they say, the warmth.

RS: Yeah. Of course people have different ears. Women I think I've heard, it's strident. Of course women hear higher pitches than men. I can remember when transistor radios and stuff came out. I can kind of hear a little difference, then from the tube stuff, so it must be something like that. But what you're getting though, I mean it doesn't annoy me at all, and to hear it all, and especially the stereo, like I say if you hear all the individual instruments and the different sections, especially from a composer's standpoint, to hear what the guy's doing, nothing is covered up, you can hear everything. And maybe because he's such a great musician, I mean he's picking really good — they're not all his performances, but whatever he picks to do are great performances. So just to sit down and listen, that's kind of what I've been listening to. I don't know, I shouldn't get too critical.

MR: Any current jazz people that you—

RS: Well I was just going to say, we get — do you know KLON?

MR: A big radio station there?

RS: Yes. In Long Beach State College. And the jazz station, they play all day long and night, 24 hours, and they're I guess on the satellite and they go all over the country. Every time I turn them on they're playing the blues.

MR: Gee.

RS: So you know I was so happy that — I live out in the desert, the high desert, and gee we've got cable, and which we got cable FM along with it. And then they got KLON on the cable, oh this is great. I'll be able to hear what guys are doing. I think it's the most accessible kind of jazz you know, blues. I don't know what other excuse they have. I'm too general, but enough that I don't even turn it on. And then of course what's considered jazz today, whatever they call new age jazz or contemporary, on the Black Entertainment Channel they had a series and I guess it's still on but it's not on at the same time, where they did like contemporary — whatever they call contemporary. I think it's gotten to be, it took the place of new age really. Because the WAVE, what is it, in L.A., I think plays that kind of stuff now, and that was originally a new age place. And the guys are great, the players, but I think it's just background music, that's what people use it for. And to

me it gets monotonous after a while. It's like we used to call "mood music." And it's just not interesting to me. I admire the performer, but just sit down for fun.

MR: It's almost the Mantovani of the 90s.

RS: Yeah. I'm hopeful it isn't that bad yet. And guys, what the heck, they're making a good living at it.

MR: Right. Well I want to thank you for coming and sharing your life story with us.

RS: Yeah. I think I covered all the bases.

MR: I hope you have a good weekend here. They seem to have you working pretty hard.

RS: Well yeah. Not today, one set.

MR: They'll probably make up for it the next three days.

RS: It's okay, it's four each day — two in the afternoons and two in the evenings.

MR: Right. Well thanks for your time, and on behalf of Hamilton College, I appreciate it.

RS: Yeah. I appreciate your having me.

MR: Okay thanks.